LECTURE-6

Understanding India through Foreign Travellers

Travel Writing as a Historical Source

Key readings: Tansen Sen, The Travel Records of Chinese Pilgrims Faxian, Xuanzang, and Yijing
M. S. Khan, A Twelfth Century Arab Account of Indian Religions and Sects

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Learning Objectives

1. **Explain what travel writings are as historical sources**
   Firsthand outsider accounts function as evidence, not just narrative.

2. **Identify different motivations behind foreign travel**
   Pilgrimage, trade, faith and curiosity all shaped why travellers came.

3. **Compare Chinese and Arab accounts of India**
   Two very different traditions of observing and recording the same land.

4. **Evaluate the strengths and limitations of travel narratives**
   Weighing eyewitness insight against bias, language gaps and selective focus.

5. **Appreciate how foreign accounts contribute to reconstructing Indian history**
   Filling gaps where indigenous records are scarce or silent.

Why Study Foreign Travellers?

If there were no Indian records for a particular period, how could historians reconstruct India's past?

POSSIBLE SOURCES

Archaeology

Physical remains of buildings and settlements

Inscriptions

Official records carved in stone or metal

Coins

Reveal rulers, dates and trade networks

Literary texts

Religious and courtly works composed in India

Foreign travellers

Outsider accounts of everyday, unremarked-upon life

Foreign travellers often noticed everyday details — diet, dress, city life — that local writers took for granted and rarely wrote down, because they were observing an unfamiliar society.

Travel Writing as a Historical Source

WHAT IS TRAVEL WRITING?

A description of a society written by someone who travelled outside their homeland — blending firsthand experience with the traveller's own outlook.

IT USUALLY RECORDS

- Geography
- Religion
- Political institutions
- Economy
- Customs
- Food
- Cities
- Trade
- Everyday life

Together, these details built a composite picture of Indian society that historians still draw on today.

TRAVEL WRITING COMBINES

1. **Observation**
   What the traveller directly witnessed
2. **Memory**
   Recalled later, often years afterward
3. **Interpretation**
   Filtered through their own worldview
4. **Personal opinion**
   Judgments about people and rulers

Methodology: Reading Travel Accounts

*Travel narratives are **not objective mirrors of reality**.*

HISTORIANS ASK

- **Why was the traveller visiting?** — *Purpose shapes what they noticed and recorded.*
- **Who was the intended audience?** — *A report for a court differs from private notes.*
- **What languages did they know?** — *Limits what they could read, ask or verify.*
- **What sources did they use?** — *Direct observation, hearsay, or earlier written accounts.*
- **What did they ignore?** — *Absences can be as telling as inclusions.*
- **What cultural assumptions shaped their observations?** — *Their own beliefs coloured how they judged what they saw.*

KEY IDEA

Travel writing is both evidence and interpretation — it tells us what happened, and how the traveller made sense of it.

Travel Writing: Advantages & Limitations

Advantages

- **Eye-witness observations** — *Direct testimony often unavailable in Indian sources.*
- **Information unavailable elsewhere** — *Details indigenous writers had no reason to record.*
- **Cross-cultural comparisons** — *Travellers compare India with places they already knew.*
- **Independent perspective** — *Distance from local politics can mean less bias.*

Limitations

- **Language barriers** — *Understanding depended on interpreters and translators.*
- **Religious bias** — *Faith could shape how customs were judged.*
- **Limited geographical experience** — *Most saw only a fraction of the subcontinent.*
- **Dependence on interpreters** — *Meaning could be lost or distorted in translation.*
- **Exaggeration** — *Marvels and dangers were sometimes overstated.*
- **Selective observation** — *Travellers noticed what struck them, not what was typical.*

Foreign Travellers to India: A Timeline

Outsiders described India across nearly 1,500 years — each shaped by a different faith, homeland and purpose.

Traveller	Century	Region
Megasthenes	4th century BCE	Greece
Faxian	5th century	China
Xuanzang	7th century	China
Yijing	7th century	China
Al-Biruni	11th century	Central Asia
Al-Shahrastani	12th century	Persia

Did all these travellers come for the same reason?

Why Did Chinese Pilgrims Come?

PRIMARY MOTIVATION

Buddhism

OBJECTIVES

- **Collect scriptures —** *Bringing authoritative Buddhist texts back to China.*
- **Visit sacred places —** *Pilgrimage to sites linked to the Buddha's life.*
- **Study Sanskrit —** *Needed to read and translate original scriptures.*
- **Learn from Indian monks —** *Direct study under recognized teachers.*
- **Carry texts back to China —** *Enabling translation projects in Chinese monasteries.*

IN TANSEN SEN'S ARGUMENT

These journeys became channels for wider cultural exchange between India and China — far beyond the transmission of religious texts alone.

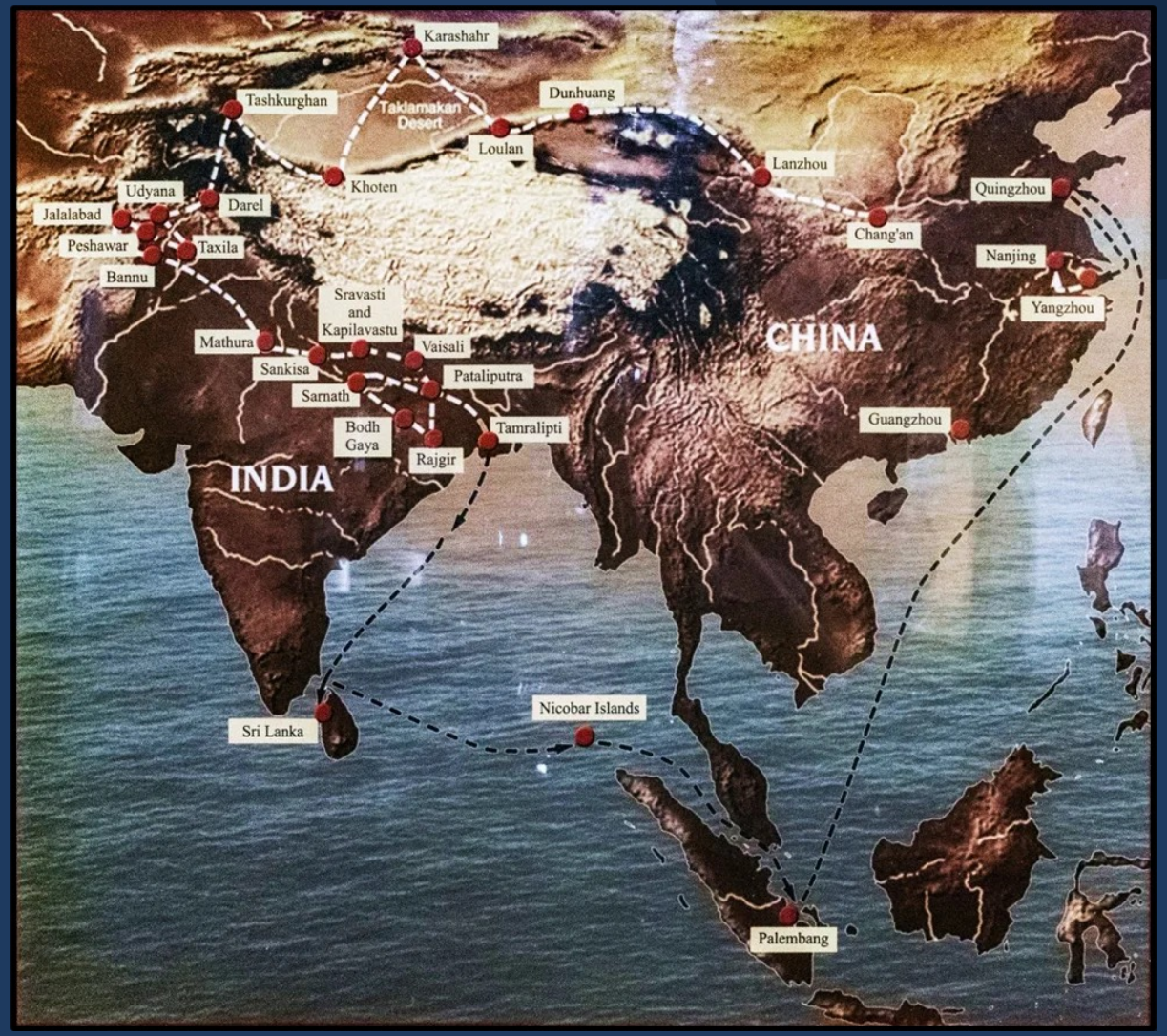
Faxian *5th century · China*

MAIN INTERESTS

- **Buddhist monasteries —** *Where he lived, studied and observed daily practice.*
- **Vinaya texts —** *Rules governing monastic discipline and conduct.*
- **Pilgrimage centres —** *Sites tied to the Buddha's life and teaching.*
- **Maritime travel —** *His return voyage via sea route and Sri Lanka.*

HISTORICAL CONTRIBUTIONS

- **Early Gupta India —** *One of the earliest outside accounts of Gupta society.*
- **Buddhist institutions —** *Details of monastic organisation and daily life.*
- **Trade routes —** *Evidence of links between India, Central Asia and China.*
- **Sri Lanka and Southeast Asia —** *Extended his account beyond India itself.*



Xuanzang

7th century · China — the greatest Chinese traveller to India

OBSERVED

- **Cities —** *Urban layout, markets and fortifications.*
- **Universities —** *Centres of learning such as Nalanda.*
- **Politics —** *Kings, courts and regional rivalries.*
- **Society —** *Caste, custom and everyday life.*
- **Economy —** *Agriculture, trade and taxation.*
- **Religion —** *Buddhist, Hindu and Jain practice side by side.*

WHY HISTORIANS VALUE HIM

- **Among the richest sources for 7th-century India —** *Few sources cover this period in such detail.*
- **Detailed, systematic, wide-ranging observation —** *He documented far more than religious life alone.*
- **Cross-checked against other evidence —** *His account often matches archaeology and inscriptions.*



Yijing

7th century · China — travelled mainly by sea

FOCUS

- **Monastic discipline —** *Rules and routines governing Buddhist monks.*
- **Buddhist education —** *How monks were trained and examined.*
- **Daily religious life —** *Ritual and practice inside monasteries.*
- **Translation —** *Rendering Sanskrit texts into Chinese.*

CONTRIBUTION

- **Shows India within a larger Asian Buddhist world —** *Connecting India to Buddhist centres across Southeast Asia.*

What Do Chinese Pilgrims Teach Historians?

THEIR WRITINGS REVEAL

Buddhist networks

Links between monasteries across Asia

Trade routes

Paths shared by monks and merchants

Universities

Centres of learning like Nalanda

Diplomacy

Contacts between courts and kingdoms

Urban life

Cities, markets and daily routines

Cultural interaction

Exchange of ideas across borders

KEY MESSAGE

Religion became a vehicle connecting Asia — moving monks, texts and ideas along the same routes as merchants and goods.

Medieval Arab Interest in India

Why were Arab scholars interested?

Trade

Commercial contact along sea and land routes

Expansion of Islam

Growing reach into South Asia

Scientific curiosity

Interest in Indian learning and method

Comparative religion

Understanding beliefs unlike their own

Translation movement in Baghdad

Rendering Indian texts into Arabic

Indian mathematics, astronomy and philosophy attracted enormous interest, feeding directly into the translation movement centred in Baghdad.

Al-Shahrastani and Indian Religions

Unlike the Chinese pilgrims, Al-Shahrastani:

- **Never visited India —** *His account rests entirely on secondhand information.*
- **Relied on earlier Arabic works —** *Compiling from existing translations and commentaries.*
- **Attempted to classify Indian religions —** *Organising them within an Islamic scholarly framework.*

His work reflects medieval Islamic scholarship rather than direct observation.

M. S. Khan's Evaluation

Khan asks: How reliable is Al-Shahrastani?

Strengths

- **Preserves medieval knowledge —** *Records views that might otherwise be lost.*
- **Systematic classification —** *Organises Indian religions into clear categories.*
- **Comparative religion —** *Places Indian belief alongside other traditions.*

Weaknesses

- **Secondary sources —** *Built on earlier texts, not firsthand study.*
- **Misunderstandings —** *Errors inherited from his written sources.*
- **Factual errors —** *Details that don't match other evidence.*
- **Religious assumptions —** *Islamic categories imposed on non-Islamic material.*

Al-Biruni versus Al-Shahrastani

Two Arab scholars, two very different relationships to their subject.

Al-Biruni	Al-Shahrastani
Visited India	Never visited
Learned Sanskrit	Did not know Sanskrit
Used original texts	Used Arabic compilations
Critical scholarship	Compilation
Primary evidence	Secondary evidence

Which source would historians trust more? Why?

Comparing Chinese and Arab Accounts

Two traditions of observing India, driven by different purposes and producing different kinds of evidence.

Chinese Pilgrims	Arab Scholars
Pilgrimage	Intellectual inquiry
Buddhism	Comparative religion
First-hand observation	Often literary sources
Monasteries	Religious classifications
Travel narrative	Encyclopaedic writing

Reading Foreign Accounts Critically

QUESTIONS HISTORIANS ASK

- **Who is speaking?** — *The traveller's identity and background shape the account.*
- **Why did they travel?** — *Purpose filters what gets recorded.*
- **What did they observe?** — *Direct observation versus secondhand report.*
- **What could they not understand?** — *Gaps created by language or unfamiliarity.*
- **What evidence supports their claims?** — *Testing claims against other sources.*
- **Can archaeology confirm them?** — *Physical evidence as an independent check.*

CONCEPT

Corroboration — checking one account against others before trusting it.

How Useful Are Foreign Travellers?

THEY HELP US UNDERSTAND

Religion	Trade	Cities
Education	Society	Diplomacy

*But they do **not** provide a complete picture.*

Their writings must always be compared with:

- **Inscriptions —** *Official, dated, and less shaped by outside bias.*
- **Archaeology —** *Physical remains that don't depend on any writer's account.*
- **Indigenous literature —** *The Indian perspective largely missing from outsider narratives.*
- **Coins —** *Independent evidence of rulers and trade.*

Larger Historical Significance

Foreign travellers show that:

- **India was deeply connected with Asia —** *Not an isolated civilization, but part of wider networks.*
- **Knowledge travelled alongside merchants —** *Ideas moved along the same routes as goods.*
- **Buddhism linked India and China —** *A shared religious world spanning two civilizations.*
- **Islamic scholarship connected India with West Asia —** *Arab scholars folded India into a larger intellectual world.*
- **Ideas moved across political boundaries —** *Exchange continued despite shifting kingdoms and empires.*

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=WlQdLLOmW3o&t=858s

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=I-pI_gANshs

Travel writing reveals the history of connections, not isolation.

Conclusion

- Travel writings are indispensable historical sources.
- They are shaped by the traveller's purpose, religion, education and audience.
- Chinese pilgrims provide valuable first-hand evidence about Buddhist India.
- Al-Shahrastani demonstrates how knowledge circulated through literary traditions rather than direct experience.
- Historians use travel narratives critically, comparing them with other forms of evidence before drawing conclusions.